agent

NOUN[1] & ADJECTIVE

Etymology

Summary

Of multiple origins. Partly a borrowing from French. Partly a borrowing from Latin.

Etymons: French *agent*; Latin *agent-*, *agēns*, *agere*.

< (i) **Middle French** *agent* (**French** *agent*) (noun) person acting on behalf of another, representative, emissary (1332 in an isolated attestation, subsequently (apparently after **Italian**) from 1578), person who or thing which acts upon someone or something (*c*1370, originally and frequently in philosophical contexts), substance that brings about a chemical effect or causes a chemical reaction (1612 (in the passage translated in quot. 1624 at sense A.4) or earlier; rare before early 19th cent.), person who intrigues (1640), (adjective) that acts, that exerts power (1337; *c*1450 in grammar; second half of the 15th cent. in *cause agent* (compare quot. 1535 at sense B)),

and its etymon (ii) **classical Latin** *agent-*, *agēns* acting, active, (masculine noun) pleader, advocate, in **post-classical Latin** also representative, official (4th cent.), administrator of an estate, employee of a church (6th cent.), (neuter noun) (in philosophy) instrumentality, cause (from 8th cent. in British sources; also in continental sources), uses as adjective and noun of present participle of *agere* to act, do (see **act** *v.*).

With sense A.1a and corresponding adjectival use compare earlier **patient** *n.* and **patient** *adj.*

Notes

Parallels in other European languages.

Compare **Catalan** *agent*, adjective and noun (14th cent.), **Spanish** *agente* (late 14th cent. as noun, early 15th cent. as adjective), **Portuguese** *agente*, adjective and noun (15th cent.), **Italian** *agente* (*a*1294 as adjective, *a*1328 as noun). Compare also **Dutch** *agent* (noun) official, representative (1570), **German** *Agent* (masculine noun) representative, emissary (1546), spy (18th cent., now the usual sense), *Agens* (neuter noun) person who or thing which acts upon someone or something (1598).

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1.a. A person who or thing which acts upon someone or something; one who or that which exerts power; the doer of an action. Sometimes contrasted with the *patient* (*instrument*, etc.) undergoing the action. Cf. **actor** *n.* 3a. **a1500–**

Earliest in *Alchemy*: a force capable of acting upon matter, an active principle. Now chiefly in philosophical and sociological contexts.

a1500 (1471) The fyrst [kind of combining] is callyd by phylosophers dyptatyve be-twyxte ye agent & ye pacyent.
G. Ripley, *Compend of Alchemy* (Ashmole MS.) l. 718

a1555 The forgeuenes of oure sinnes..is onely gods worke & we nothing els but patientes & not agentes.
J. Bradford, *Godlie Medit. Lordes Prayer* (1562) sig. Q.ii

1614 For he maketh foure originals, whereof three are agents, and the last passiue and materiall.
W. Raleigh, *History of World* i.i. i. §6. 6

1646 Nor are we to be meer instruments moved by the will of those in authority..but are morall Agents.
S. Bolton, *Arraignment of Errour* 295

1788 He that is not free is not an *agent*, but a *patient*.
J. Wesley, *Serm. Several Occasions* vol. V. 177

1809 *Agent and Patient*, when the same person is the doer of a thing, and the party to whom done: as where a woman endows herself of the best part of her husband's possessions.
T. E. Tomlins, *Jacob's Law-dictionary*

1870 In conformity with this view, the distinction between agent and patient, between something which acts and some other thing which is acted upon, is formally abolished.
F. C. Bowen, *Logic* xii. 401

1909 We are..conversant with the fact in human affairs that whenever purpose is involved there is an intelligent agent.
Popular Science Monthly April 379

1989 It is silly to berate the hurricane for irresponsibility... It..cannot be a true agent; it cannot author or own an action.
C. T. Sistare, *Responsibility & Criminal Liability* ii. iv. 15

2010 It is only an exercise of power if the agent gets the subject to do something whether or not the subject wants to do it.
J. R. Searle, *Making Social World* vii. 152

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1571 Faieth is produced and brought foorth by the grace of God, as chiefe agent and worker thereof.
W. Fulke, *Confut. Popishe Libelle* (new edition) f. 108ᵛ

1592 I stepped back againe into the garden,..leauing them still agents of these vnkind villanies.
R. Greene, *Philomela* sig. F4ᵛ

1645 The fire warmeth more at a neer, then at a remoter distance: Naturall agents work not *in distans*.
A. Ross, *Philosophicall Touch-stone* 35

1666 Whether or no the Shape can by Physical Agents be alter'd.., yet mentally both..can be done.
R. Boyle, *Origine of Formes & Qualities* 9

1699 When the Samians invaded Zancle, a..great Agent in that affair was Hippocrates.
R. Bentley, *Dissertation upon Epistles of Phalaris* (new edition) 155

1719 I was still to be the wilful Agent of all my own Miseries.
D. Defoe, *Life Robinson Crusoe* 43

1722 Nor can I think, that any body has such an idea of chance, as to make it an agent or really existing and acting cause of any thing.
W. Wollaston, *Religion of Nature* v. 60

1848 Successful production..depends more on the qualities of the human agents, than on the circumstances in which they work.
J. S. Mill, *Principles of Political Economy* vol. I. i. vii. 123

1875 The Rhizopods were important agents in the accumulation of beds of limestone.
J. W. Dawson, *Life's Dawn on Earth* vi. 134

1904 The glacier will be efficient as the agent for débris removal.
Journal of Geology (Chicago) vol. 12 574

1963 The key idea of man as the agent for the whole future of evolution.
J. S. Huxley, *Human Crisis* 19

2010 At Cambridge..I had no theories about theatre as an agent of social or political change.
S. Fry, *Fry Chronicles* 94

1.c. *Grammar*. The doer of an action, typically expressed as the subject of an active verb or in a *by*-phrase with a passive verb. **c1620–**

Cf. **agent noun** *n.*

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1764 *Reflective*..action returns upon the agent that produces it, as, I *flatter myself* & c.
C. Wiseman, *Compl. English Grammar* 155

1771 An active verb..necessarily supposes an agent, and an object acted upon; as..*I praise John*.
D. Fenning, *New Gram. English Tongue* 32

1845 It often becomes necessary to state the object of a verb active, or the agent of a verb passive. Hence arises the necessity for..the accusative and the ablative.
Encyclopædia Metropolitana (1847) vol. I. 33/1

1953 With an intransitive verb the subject is as much a patient as an agent. *I walk* is as much 'I cause my walking' as 'I experience my walking'.
W. J. Entwhistle, *Aspects of Language* vi. 179

2007 Truck driver is an acceptable (and existing) compound..but child-driver is not acceptable..since child is the agent of the verb.
N. Tsujimura, *Introd. Japanese Linguistics* iv. vii. 166

grammar

1.d. *Parapsychology*. In telepathy: the person who originates an impression (opposed to the *percipient* who receives it). **1883–**

1883 In Thought-transference..both parties (whom, for convenience' sake, we will call the Agent and the Percipient) are supposed to be in a normal state.
Proceedings of Society for Psychical Research 1882–3 vol. 1 119

1886 We call the owner of the impressing mind the *agent*, and the owner of the impressed mind the *percipient*.
E. Gurney et al., *Phantasms of Living* vol. I. 6

1961 Spontaneous cases [of telepathy] do occasionally occur in which no such connection between apparent agent and apparent percipient can be traced.
W. H. Salter, *Zoar* xi. 149

1990 Analytical attention..has shifted down the years from agent (sender) to percipient (receiver).
L. Picknett, *Encycl. Paranormal* 218/1

parapsychology

2. A person acting on behalf of another.

2.a. A person who acts as a substitute for another: one who undertakes negotiations or **1523–**

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1523 We have ben with the Cardinall de Medices agentes.
in *State Papers Henry VIII* (1849) vol. VI. 181

1548 Ioanna the wyfe of Chusa Herodes agent and factour [Latin *procuratoris*].
N. Udall et al., translation of Erasmus, *Paraphrase Newe Testamente* vol. I. Luke xxiv. f. clxxxiiii

***a*1593** Goe call the English Agent hether strait.
C. Marlowe, *Massacre at Paris* (*c*1600) sig. D5

1607 Dioclesian..was agent for the Romans in France.
E. Topsell, *Historie of Foure-footed Beastes* 698

1642 Made themselves a prey to their sollicitors and Agents.
J. Howell, *Instructions for Forreine Travell* xix. 230

1704 Mr. John Pain, Agent to the Regiment.
London Gazette mmmmxxviii/4

1745 Agent, that is, rent-gatherer, to the dean.
M. Delany, *Autobiography & Correspondence* (1861) vol. II. 362

1818 He..employed a certain Mr. Crabtree as his agent, steward, etc.
M. R. Mitford in A. G. L'Estrange, *Life of Mary Russell Mitford* (1870) vol. II. xi. 22

1826 Since the devil fell from Heaven, he never wanted agents on earth.
W. Scott, *Woodstock* vol. I. iii. 93

1853 I told them flatly..that, as Mr. Egerton's agent, I would allow no proceedings that might vitiate the election.
E. Bulwer-Lytton, *My Novel* vol. IV. xii. xxvii. 191

1882 An agent who signs his name to a promissory note, etc. without indicating thereon that he signs as agent, is liable personally on the instrument.
Negotiable Instruments Act (India) 40

1944 In inviting tenders for a target contract the employer, or his agent, prepares a rough estimate of the proposed work.
W. T. Cresswell in R. Greenhalgh, *Practical Builder* xv. 420/1

1983 Furthermore, that individual must be..an officer, employee or agent of such an issuing manager.
B. A. K. Rider, *Insider Trading* i. 42

2000 In the event of illness, a durable power of attorney enabled her nephew to act as her agent.
M. M. Shenkman, *Complete Living Trusts Prog.* i. 20

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Frequently with modifying word or phrase specifying the product or service.

advertising, *employment*, *estate*, *insurance*, *letting*, *railroad*, *shipping*, *tourist*, *travel agent*, etc.: see the first element.

1707 Most Bills of Exchange are ordinarily Negotiated by the..Interposition of a certain Set of Men commonly called Agents, or Brokers of Exchange.
A. Justice, *General Treatise of Monies* 19

1789 To prevent trouble, it is requested, that no..advertising Agent, will apply.
World 11 December

1812 I hope then the agent will give you encouragement about them mines.
M. Edgeworth, *Absentee* xii, in *Tales of Fashionable Life* vol. VI. 214

1844 Ship Agent and Broker.
Rep. Commissioners 1841 Census: Occup. Abstracts vol. XIII. 281

1885 Railway Excursion Agents..Cook Thomas & Son.
List of Subscribers Exchange Syst. (United Telephone Co.) (ed. 6) 181

1913 We are agents for the celebrated Scotch Wool Art Rugs.
Rotarian May 64 (advertisement)

1927 The firm of Lewisohn Brothers..had been the selling agents for the Montana Copper Company's product.
Quarterly Journal of Economics vol. 41 268

1971 Be completely honest with your agent about how much you really want..to spend. If you have only $500 for a vacation, say so.
New York Magazine 31 May 38

1992 Few..callers have to wait more than 30 seconds to speak to an agent.
Network World 14 December 69

2007 It's the house of our dreams... I told the agent we'd meet him three at five o'clock.
J. Mansell, *Thinking of You* xlvi. 332

2.c. In colonial North America and subsequently the United States: an official appointed to represent the government in dealing with an Indigenous people; = **Indian agent** *n.* Now *historical*. **1707–**

1707 Thomas Nairne..is..appointed y^e^ Agent to reside among y^e^ Indians.
Act regulating Indian Trade (S. Carolina Dept. Archives: S 165001)

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1886 There can be but one head to an Indian agency, and the agent should be that head, if discipline is to be maintained.
Captain Bell, *Report* in *Nation* (1888) 15 March 211/1

1968 As one former Peigan chief expressed it, 'the agents pulled us back instead of pushing us forward'.
Lethbridge (Alberta) *Herald* 9 November 5/4

1979 Pressure on the Ioways to sell their land was also increased, as the agent continued to inquire if all the agency tribes would not care to sell.
M. R. Blaine, *Ioway Indians* viii. 246

2000 When a new Tulalip agent found unmarried men and women living together, he threatened to separate them.
A. Harmon, *Indians in Making* vi. 116

historical

2.d. A person who works secretly to obtain information for a government or other official body; a spy. **1804–**

double, *secret*, *treble agent*, etc.: see the first element.

1804 This agent [French *agent*], spy, and emigrant, who has received his pardon, was already known to the Police.
translation of C. Regnier, *Letter* 18 April in *Revolutionary Plutarch* (new edition) vol. III. 215

1854 When despatches from an agent of the enemy are carried by a neutral ship,..the plea of ignorance [etc.].
W. Hazlitt & H. P. Roche, *Manual Law Maritime Warfare* 235

1932 The agent clutching his side collapsed at our feet, 'Sorry! They got me!'
W. H. Auden, *Orators* iii. 108

1946 Switzerland..had been full of German agents.
Annual Register 1945 230

1956 Relaying secret information to Russian agents.
A. H. Compton, *Atomic Quest* ii. 117

2008 Studying at various K.G.B. schools, ending at Moscow institute that prepared agents for work abroad.
Vanity Fair (New York) October 382/3

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1825 Mr. Schemer, the agent, had no situation for our hero upon his books, but Proteus heard..that Mr. Make-a-bill..was in great want of a person at his theatre.
P. Egan, *Life of Actor* vi. 220

1892 By an early hour of the numbered evening I might have been observed..dining with my agent.
R. L. Stevenson & L. Osbourne, *Wrecker* vi. 95

1917 The name on the door was Abe Riesbitter, Vaudeville Agent, and from the other side of the door came the sound of many voices.
P. G. Wodehouse, *Man with Two Left Feet* 34

1946 Mr Watt, my agent, and Mr Faber, my publisher, have Daimlers and country cottages.
P. Larkin, *Letter* 28 July in *Selected Letters* (1992) 120

1970 Her agent..was nonplussed. 'Look, baby,' he gently chided, 'we're walking away with one million..dollars a picture.'
T. Southern, *Blue Movie* i. viii. 64

1983 Agents, often to justify their percentage when all they really do for a big star is make a phone call, are geniuses when it comes to new things to ask for.
W. Goldman, *Adventures in Screen Trade* 18

2003 [She] was no longer the timid, inexperienced ingénue..protected by her agent.
C. Fifield in K. Ferrier, *Letters & Diaries* iii. 58

theatre finance

2.f. U.S. A stagecoach robber; = **road agent** *n.* Now *historical*. **1876–**

1876 The driver finally succeeded in satisfying the 'agent' that no express box was carried by San Andreas.
Weekly Calaveras Chronicle (Mokelumne Hill, California) 29 July 3/1

1880 We reached it before long, and concluded that the 'agents', or robbers, had an excellent eye for position.
A. A. Hayes, *New Colorado* (1881) xi. 154

1904 Nex' time I drives stage some of these yere agents massacrees me from behind a bush.
S. E. White, *Blazed Trail Stories* ii. iii. 155

1970 The agents developed a system of marking departing stagecoaches that were carrying treasure so that confederates would know which ones to stop.
H. S. Drago, *Great Range Wars* xviii. 207

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Sometimes overlapping with sense A.1b.

1579 The gallowes is no agent or doer in those good thinges.
W. Fulke, *Heskins Parleament Repealed* in *D. Heskins Ouerthrowne* 621

1593 Not a nayle in it [*sc.* the Crosse] but is a necessary Agent in the Worlds redemption.
T. Nashe, *Christs Teares* 21/1

***a*1616** Here is her hand, the agent of her heart.
W. Shakespeare, *Two Gentlemen of Verona* (1623) i. iii. 46

1654 God doth often good works by ill agents.
J. Bramhall, *Just Vindication of Church of England* iii. 43

1793 War, which is the agent which must in general be employed upon these occasions, presents..an uncertain court of judicature.
B. Vaughan, *Letters Concert of Princes* p. iii

1842 Nature..Thro' many agents making strong, Matures the individual form.
Lord Tennyson, *Love thou thy Land* in *Poems* (new edition) vol. I. 225

1878 Whatever thus furnishes us with the first requisite of production is called a natural agent, that is, something which acts for us and assists us.
W. S. Jevons, *Political Economy* 26

1920 Money is the agent through which good purposes are made effective.
Intellect vol. 12 233/2

2002 [In Marlowe's physiology] the arteries..carry the vital spirit..which is the agent by which the soul effects movement.
Y. Takahashi in S. W. Wells, *Shakespeare Surv.* 181

4. *Chemistry*. A substance that brings about a chemical or physical effect or causes a chemical reaction. In later use chiefly with preceding modifying word specifying the nature of the effect or reaction. Cf. **reagent** *n.* 2. **1624–**

alkylating, *oxidizing*, *reducing*, *wetting agent*, etc.: see the first element.

1624 The vinegre..is the onely Agent [French *l'vnique agent*; Latin *solum medium aptum*] in the whole World for this Art, that can resolue and reincrudate, or make raw againe the Mettallicke Bodies.
'E. Orandus', translation of N. Flamel, *Expos. Hieroglyphicall Figures St. Innocent's Church-yard* 159

1671 The agent in the change wrought by Petrification, is..a petrific Seed, consisting only in a

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1797 Some observations on the sthenic or asthenic virtue of chemical agents, that is to say, their ability or impotence to produce irritation.
Monthly Magazine vol. 3 350/2

1827 This quantity is..wholly available in the liquid when used as a bleaching agent.
M. Faraday, *Exper. Research* xli. §12. 226

1858 Oxalic acid is mostly to be preferred as the precipitating agent.
T. Graham, *Elements of Chemistry* (ed. 2) vol. II. viii. 361

1950 Piperoxane hydrochloride is an adrenergic-blocking agent of short duration of action.
Dispensatory U.S.A. (ed. 24) vol. II. 2016/2

1962 Xenon tetrafluoride, when dissolved in hydrogen fluoride, is a moderately strong fluorinating agent.
Science 12 October 137/2

2011 Bleaches marketed as color-safe..use weaker oxidizing agents.
Wisconsin State Journal (Nexis) 3 October a2

chemistry

5. *Computing*. A program that (autonomously) performs a task such as information retrieval or processing on behalf of a client or user. More fully **software agent**, **user agent**. **1970–**

1970 An algorithm is a set of instructions of finite size, requires a computing agent to 'react' to the instructions, requires facilities (resources) for storage and control, [etc.].
Advances in Computers vol. 10 15

1981 The model consists of a Message Transfer System and a number of User Agents.
Request for Comments (Network Working Group) (Electronic text) No.806. 8

1984 Little software 'agents' that scurry back and forth between human and program to retrieve precisely what the human wants.
Washington Post (Nexis) 2 September g2

1990 This can provide a 'user agent' capability so that, for example, the user is informed as soon as he logs in if there is mail waiting for him.
ICL Technical Journal vol. 7 424

2008 5 per cent is how much more profit a sharetrading software agent can make by learning when to bid aggressively and when to cut its losses.
London Lite (Nexis) 3 July 13

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1535 The fynall necessytie also, and the cause agent [Latin *causam agentem*] or effectyue wherof.
W. Marshall, translation of Marsilius of Padua, *Defence of Peace* i. viii. f. 67ᵛ

1575 The ayre being more thin and liquide then the water, and more vnable to resist, is sooner and more easily affected by externall and agent [Latin *agentibus*] qualities.
translation of L. Daneau, *Dialogue Witches* iii. sig. E.vii

1615 Hughe Mill and Elinor his wife the parties agentes in this cause and William delve defendent.
in B. Cusack, *Everyday English 1500–1700* (1998) 24

1620 What a hot fellow Sol (whom all Agent Causes follow).
J. Melton, *Astrologaster* 13

1704 The proper office of this agent intellect, to serve as an under-labourer to that which is patient.
J. Norris, *Essay Ideal World* vol. II. vii. 350

1856 Agent or patient, singly or one of a crowd.
T. De Quincey, *Confessions Eng. Opium-eater* (revised edition) in *Selections Grave & Gay* vol. V. 83

1949 The Philosopher is speaking in that passage not of the agent cause but of the formal cause.
M. C. Fitzpatrick, translation of St. Thomas Aquinas, *On Spiritual Creatures* i. 25

2009 The [Philippine] people have transmogrified from..an identification with the Christ child..into an agent force of revolution.
N. X. M. Tadiar, *Things fall Away* vii. 290

Pronunciation

BRITISH ENGLISH

/ˈeɪdʒ(ə)nt/

AY-juhnt

U.S. ENGLISH

/ˈeɪdʒ(ə)nt/

AY-juhnt

Pronunciation keys

Forms

Variant forms

late Middle English– **agent**

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Frequency

agent is one of the 1,000 most common words in modern written English. It is similar in frequency to words like *agree*, *distribution*, *kill*, *military*, and *sell*.

It typically occurs about 100 times per million words in modern written English.

agent is in frequency band 7, which contains words occurring between 100 and 1,000 times per million words in modern written English. More about OED's frequency bands

Frequency data is computed programmatically, and should be regarded as an estimate.

Frequency of *agent, n.*[1] *& adj.*, 1750–2010

* Occurrences per million words in written English

Historical frequency series are derived from Google Books Ngrams (version 2), a data set based on the Google Books corpus of several million books printed in English between 1500 and 2010.

The overall frequency for a given word is calculated by summing frequencies for the main form of the word, any plural or inflected forms, and any major spelling variations.

For sets of homographs (distinct entries that share the same word-form, e.g. *mole*, n.[1], *mole*, n.[2], *mole*, n.[3],

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Frequency of *agent, n.¹ & adj.*, 2017–2023

* Occurrences per million words in written English

Modern frequency series are derived from a corpus of 20 billion words, covering the period from 2017 to the present. The corpus is mainly compiled from online news sources, and covers all major varieties of World English.

Compounds & derived words

Sort by Date (oldest first)

nihilagent, n. **1579–80**
A person who does nothing.

agentry, n. **1590–**
The office or function of an agent (in various senses); the activity or occupation of an agent or agency; the process or fact of being an agent...

vice-agent, n. **1597**

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mis-agent, n. 1625

non-agent, n. 1632–

smock-agent, n. 1632–

agent, v. 1637–
transitive. To act as agent in (some business or process); to conduct or carry out as agent. Also: to act as an agent for (a person or project).

agenting, n. 1646–
The business or process of acting as an agent (in various senses); the profession of an agent.

foreign agent, n. 1646–
A person who represents or acts on behalf of one country while located in another; (in later use spec.) a person who works secretly to obtain...

free agent, n. 1649–
a. A person able to act freely, as by the exercise of free will, or because of the absence of restriction, constraint, or responsibilities; b. Sport...

reagent, n. 1656–
Chemistry. A substance used in testing for other substances, or for reacting with them in a particular way; (more widely) any substance used in...

agent general, n. 1659–
spec. (sometimes with capital initials). Formerly: the representative of a British colony in London (now historical). Later: the representative of an...

under-agent, n. 1677–
A sub-agent.

subagent, n. 1683–
A subordinate agent; (U.S. Law) an agent authorized to transact business or otherwise act on behalf of another.

chemical agent, n. 1728–
A chemical substance producing a specific effect, esp. when intentionally used for this reason; (now often) spec. a substance used to incapacitate...

inter-agent, n. 1728–
An intermediate agent; a go-between, intermediary.

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crown agent, n. **1753–**
An agent for the Crown; spec. (usually with capital initials) (a) in Scotland, a law officer who takes charge of criminal proceedings, acting under...

agentess, n. **1757–**
A female agent.

navy agent, n. **1765–**
A person or firm responsible for managing the financial affairs of naval officers; (formerly also) †a paymaster or purser in the U.S. navy (obsolete).

Indian agent, n. **1766–**
An official authorized to represent the U.S. federal government in its dealings with an Indigenous people; (in Canada) the chief government...

prize agent, n. **1766–**
An agent appointed for the sale of prizes taken in maritime war.

field agent, n. **1773–**
An agent (now esp. an intelligence agent) who works away from a central office or headquarters.

advertising agent, n. **1775–**

purchasing agent, n. **1777–**

coal agent, n. **1778–**

federal agent, n. **1781–**
A representative of the U.S. federal government, (now) esp. a federal law-enforcement officer.

newspaper agent, n. **1781–**

agent noun, n. **1782–**
A noun (in English typically one ending in -er or -or) denoting someone or something that performs the action of a verb, as worker, accelerator, etc.

estate agent, n. **1787–**
A person or company involved in the business or profession of arranging the sale, purchase, or rental of buildings and land for clients. Also (also...

revenue agent, n. **1787–**

recruiting agent, n. **1792–**

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An agent (now typically a professional one) who acts on behalf of an author in dealing with publishers and others involved in promoting his or her...

theatrical agent, n. **1797–**
An agent whose business is to act as an intermediary between actors looking for work and those seeking to employ them.

commission agent, n. **1798–**
†a. = commission broker, n. (a) (obsolete); b. an agent who conducts business or trade for another party on the principle of commission (commission...

book agent, n. **1810–**
A person who promotes the sale of books; (now) spec. a literary agent (cf. agent, n.[1] A.2e).

forwarding agent, n. **1810–**
A person or business that organizes the shipment or transportation of goods.

newsagent, n. **1811–**
A dealer in newspapers and periodicals, esp. the owner of a shop where these are sold; (now also) the shop itself, usually also selling tobacco...

police agent, n. **1813–**

ship-agent, n. **1813**
A shipping agent.

oxidizing agent, n. **1814–**
A substance that brings about oxidation and in the process is itself reduced.

press agent, n. **1814–**
A person employed to organize advertising and publicity in the press on behalf of an organization or person.

reducing agent, n. **1816–**
A substance that brings about chemical reduction and in the process is itself oxidized; cf. oxidizing agent, n.

parliamentary agent, n. **1819–**
A person professionally employed to take charge of the interests of a party concerned in or affected by any private legislation.

counter-agent, n. **1821–**

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business agent, n. **1831–**

customs agent, n. **1838–**
= customs officer, n.

mine agent, n. **1839–**

agentive, adj. & n. **1840–**
Of or relating to an agent or agency (see agent, n.¹ A.1c); indicating or having the semantic role of an agent.

railroad agent, n. **1840–**

road agent, n. **1840–**
†a. An agent or driver for a stagecoach company (obsolete); b. a robber who steals from travellers or holds up vehicles on the road (now historical).

rogue agent, n. **1840–**

station agent, n. **1840–**
a. Chiefly U.S. a person in charge of a railway or (formerly) stagecoach station; b. a person who works for (a particular branch of) an intelligence...

fining agent, n. **1843–**
A substance used to clarify a liquid; spec. (a) a substance used to remove organic compounds from a liquid, esp. beer or wine, to improve the clarity...

freight agent, n. **1843–**

shipping-agent, n. **1843–**
A licensed agent who transacts a ship's business for the owner.

goods agent, n. **1844–**

intelligence agent, n. **1844–**

patent agent, n. **1845–**

land-agent, n. **1846–**
A steward or manager of landed property; also, an agent for the sale of land, an estate agent.

change agent, n. **1847–**
A person who initiates social or political change within a group or institution.

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booking agent, n. 1849–

a. A person who or a business which arranges transport or travel for goods or passengers, or sells tickets in advance for concerts, plays, or other... Frequently derogatory in early use, denoting agents for railway or shipping companies who issued tickets or passes which were greatly overpriced or invalid; cf. booker, n. 3a.

passenger agent, n. 1852–

fixing agent, n. 1855–

baggage-agent, n. 1858–

employment agent, n. 1859–

An individual acting as a professional intermediary between applicants for work and employers.

claim-agent, n. 1860–

matrimonial agent, n. 1860–

personation agent, n. 1864–

An official employed at an election to detect people attempting to vote under a false name.

advance agent, n. 1865–

An agent who is sent on ahead of a main party (cf. advance man, n.); also figurative.

transfer agent, n. 1869–

information agent, n. 1871–

mission-agent, n. 1871–

lecture agent, n. 1873–

publicity agent, n. 1877–

agent word, n. 1879–

A word that indicates agency or active force; esp. a word that denotes the doer of an action; = agent noun, n.

personating agent, n. 1879–

= personation agent, n.

rental agent, n. 1880–

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A substance, such as yeast or baking powder, which is used in dough or batter to make it rise during (and sometimes before) baking.

travel agent, n. **1885–**
A person who owns or works for a travel agency; (also) a travel agency.

polling agent, n. **1887–**
An official overseeing an election on behalf of a candidate; (later also) a canvasser at a polling station on the day of an election.

special agent, n. **1893–**
A person who conducts investigations on behalf of the government; (now) spec. (U.S.) a person who conducts criminal investigations and has arrest...

transport-agent, n. **1897–**

alkylating agent, n. **1900–**
A substance that brings about alkylation; (Pharmacology) any of a class of cytotoxic immunosuppressant drugs which alkylate DNA and are used in...

addition agent, n. **1909–**
(In electrodeposition) a substance which is added to an electrolyte, typically in small quantities, in order to modify the quality of the deposit...

site agent, n. **1910–**
a. An agent authorized to inspect, survey, and purchase land for development (rare); b. (in the construction industry) a person responsible for...

marketing agent, n. **1915–**

harassing agent, n. **1919–**
A non-lethal chemical which is deployed in the form of a gas or aerosol and used to incapacitate an enemy or disperse a crowd; = harassing gas, n.

contrast agent, n. **1924–**
A substance introduced into a part of the body to enhance the quality of a radiographic image by increasing the contrast of internal structures with...

binding agent, n. **1933–**
A substance that assists cohesion (cf. bind, v. III.10).

stock-agent, n. **1933–**

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sports agent, n. **1943–**
A person who represents a professional athlete in financial and contractual matters.

sleeper agent, n. **1945–**
= sleeper, n. I.2d.

bioagent, n. **1950–**
A harmful or disease-producing microorganism, biopesticide, biotoxin, etc., esp. one used in warfare or for the purposes of terrorism.

G-agent, n. **1953–**
Any of a group of four organophosphorus nerve agents originally developed by German scientists during the Second World War, characterized by being...

uncoupling agent, n. **1956–**
= uncoupler, n.

stripping agent, n. **1958–**

nerve agent, n. **1960–**
A substance that alters the functioning of the nervous system, typically inhibiting neurotransmission; esp. one used as a weapon, a nerve gas.

Agent Orange, n. **1966–**
A defoliant and herbicide used by the United States during the Vietnam War to remove forest cover and destroy crops. Cf. agent, n.¹ & adj.compounds...

penetration agent, n. **1966–**
A spy sent to penetrate an enemy organization.

treble agent, n. **1967–**
A spy who works for three countries, his or her superiors in each being informed of his or her service to the other, but usually with actual...

triple agent, n. **1968–**
= treble agent, n.

managing agent, n. **1969–**
A person responsible for administering or managing an activity (esp. a sale) on behalf of another; (Insurance) a manager of an underwriting syndicate...

masking agent, n. **1977–**

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